Kyoto Neighborhood Guide

Gion

Kyoto's historic geisha district. Wooden machiya townhouses, teahouses and the Shirakawa Canal. Very quiet after 22:00, crowded with day visitors 10:00-17:00. Dining is mostly high-end kaiseki; vegetarian options are limited. Nearest stations: Gion-Shijo (Keihan) and Kawaramachi (Hankyu). Mostly flat, but cobbled lanes.

Arashiyama

Western Kyoto, scenic and nature-focused. Bamboo grove, Togetsukyo Bridge, Tenryu-ji. Best before 09:00 to avoid crowds. Many casual cafes and tofu restaurants (good vegetarian choices). About 30 minutes from central Kyoto by JR Sagano Line.

Kyoto Station Area

Transport hub with the Haruka Express to Kansai Airport (about 80 minutes). Large chain hotels, shopping, ramen alley. Fully step-free with elevators. Lively until late; best base for late arrivals.

Higashiyama

Eastern hills with Kiyomizu-dera and preserved streets (Sannenzaka, Ninenzaka). Steep slopes and stairs; limited accessibility. Very busy in autumn foliage season (mid-November).